

# The Man Leopard Murders and Contemporary Trust in the Nigerian Criminal Justice Institutions \*

Ada Johnson-Kanu<sup>†</sup>

Godwin Okore<sup>‡</sup>

## Abstract

Between 1943 and 1948, more than 200 people were killed in Calabar Province, Nigeria, by individuals disguised as leopards. The colonial administration responded with the largest police investigation in Nigerian colonial history and a public court process that resulted in the arrest of 96 suspects and the execution of 77 persons found guilty by the court. We examine whether these events generated long-term trust in criminal justice institutions. Using geolocated Afrobarometer data (rounds 3–9) matched to historical boundaries, we find that residents of Calabar Province report substantially higher trust in courts than residents of the surrounding South East region. The effect is specific to courts: placebo tests on six other outcomes of institutional trust are null. Trust in the police is elevated only within the Man Leopard zone itself, where the police investigation was concentrated. Cohort analysis shows the trust-in-courts advantage is concentrated among the 1940s and 1980s birth cohorts; and the effect is stronger among men, consistent with the gendered transmission of memory about the events. The court trial left a more durable legacy than the police investigation, suggesting that visible judicial resolution of community crises can build lasting institutional trust.

**Keywords:** colonial legacies; institutional trust; courts; policing; Nigeria

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<sup>†</sup>Assistant Professor of Political Science, University of Kentucky. [anjohnson-kanu@uky.edu](mailto:anjohnson-kanu@uky.edu)

<sup>‡</sup>PhD student in Political Science, University of Kentucky. [godwin.okore@uky.edu](mailto:godwin.okore@uky.edu)

# 1. Introduction

Trust in justice institutions has well-documented downstream consequences for governance and public safety. Citizens who trust the police are more likely to report crimes, cooperate in investigations, and comply voluntarily with the law (Tyler, 2003; Sunshine and Tyler, 2003). Where trust is absent, citizens turn to informal and extralegal alternatives (vigilantism, mob justice, private security) that undermine the rule of law (Tankebe, 2009; Akinlabi, 2022b). Understanding how institutional trust is built and whether it can persist across generations, therefore, has direct implications for whether formal justice institutions can function effectively.

In the mid-1940s, communities across the Calabar Province in Eastern Nigeria lived in terror. More than 200 people had been murdered by individuals disguised as leopards, their bodies mutilated with iron claws to mimic animal attacks. Traditional authorities could not stop the killings and the local leaders were either powerless or complicit. The colonial administration intervened with the largest police investigation in Nigerian colonial history and a court process that led to the conviction of 96 suspects and the execution of 77 persons linked to the murders. Eight decades later, we ask if residents of Calabar Province trust the police and courts differently than their neighbors?

This question sits at the intersection of two strands of literature that rarely speak to each other. Research on colonial legacy documents how historical institutions shape contemporary governance (Acemoglu et al., 2001; Eck, 2018), but focuses on institutional capacity and organizational structure rather than community-level trust<sup>1</sup>. Research on procedural justice and institutional legitimacy (Tyler, 2006; Sunshine and Tyler, 2003) examines how citizens form attitudes toward police and courts, yet rarely considers how formative historical episodes create baseline expectations that shape trust for generations. We bridge these literature by examining how two components of the colonial criminal justice response, polic-

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<sup>1</sup>see Nunn and Wantchekon (2011) on interpersonal trust.

ing, and judicial trials, generated different attitudinal legacies that persist in contemporary times.

We argue that the colonial criminal justice response to the Man Leopard murders altered how residents perceived state institutions through instrumental legitimacy: the state eliminated a security threat that communities could not resolve on their own (Nwaka, 1986; Pratten, 2007). We distinguish trust generated by the police investigation (coercive but effective) from trust generated by the court process (conviction and public execution of perpetrators), and expect the visible finality of judicial resolution to leave a more durable legacy than the police investigation.

Using geolocated Afrobarometer data (BenYishay et al., 2017) from rounds 3–9 matched to historical boundaries, we find that residents of Calabar Province report greater trust in courts than residents of the South East Region. Placebo tests on six other trust outcomes are null. Trust in the police is elevated only within the Man Leopard zone. Calabar respondents who report difficulty accessing police help experience a higher trust penalty than comparable respondents elsewhere, consistent with the asymmetry thesis that trust is hard to win and easy to lose (Oliveira et al., 2021).

These findings contribute to the literature in three ways. First, we complement Eck (2018)’s institutional account of colonial security legacies by showing that effective policing and adjudication can generate distinct attitudinal legacies, with court-based resolution producing more durable trust. Second, we extend the literature on colonial legacies by showing that the effects of historical events on contemporary attitudes vary by institutional channel, depend on migration patterns, and are specific to the relevant institutional domain (Acemoglu et al., 2001; Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011; Lowes and Montero, 2021). Third, we contribute to research on institutional legitimacy by providing evidence that efficient judicial resolution of community threats can build lasting trust in ways that police alone cannot, with implications for post-conflict justice and security sector reform (Blair et al., 2021; Ansorg, 2017).

## 2. Historical Background

The Man Leopard affected area encompassed 130 villages in the Abak and Opobo districts of the Calabar Province, home to a predominantly Ibibio-speaking agricultural population of 150,000 to 200,000 people (Nwaka, 1986). In the absence of centralized traditional authority, secret societies performed governance, judicial, and spiritual functions. The Ekpe (“leopard”) society served as a local governance institution, while the Idiong functioned as a divination order (Pratten, 2007). Since attacks by real leopards were common, perpetrators could disguise murders by using iron claws that left marks resembling leopard pads.

The Second World War created conditions for the outbreak. The colonial administration was severely understaffed, the economic depression intensified conflicts over labor, debts, and land, and the withdrawal of colonial personnel left a governance vacuum that secret societies filled (Nwaka, 1986). Between 1943 and 1948, more than 200 mutilated bodies were discovered. Communities could not resolve the crisis because the responsible secret societies were embedded in local governance and the villagers feared retaliation for speaking (Pratten, 2007). In February 1945, District Officer Frederick Kay, prompted by a report in the *Nigerian Eastern Mail*, ordered the exhumation of a supposed victim of a leopard murder and discovered that the wounds were inflicted by a person, not a leopard.

The colonial state acted through two institutional channels to address the issue. The *police investigation* (1946–1948) deployed a “leopard force” of 95 officers under a “nuisance policy” designed to saturate the affected area with visible policing until residents volunteered information (Pratten, 2007). Abak and Opobo were declared “proclaimed districts” with expanded powers of search, arrest, and detention. Curfews, house-to-house searches and coerced confessions generated resentment, and the investigation broke the wall of silence, resulting in outcomes that link individuals to murder while enabling successful prosecution of the suspects (Nwaka, 1986).

The *court processes* were public and province-wide. The suspects were tried before the

colonial courts in Calabar. The courts convicted 96 men and executed 77 by hanging (Nwaka, 1986; Pratten, 2007). In February 1947, the colonial government banned the Idiong society throughout Calabar Province. By 1948 the killings had ceased, effectively putting an end to the threat of the Man Leopard murder within these communities. The *Nigerian Eastern Mail* covered the investigation, trials, and executions, carrying the justice response to communities outside the immediate murder zone (Pratten, 2007).

The two channels differed in how they reached the communities. The investigation was experienced locally as an intrusion: curfews, arbitrary detentions, property seizures and coercion. The court process delivered formal justice through evidence, judicial trial, and punishment, and did so in public view throughout the province. This distinction motivates our expectation that the two channels generated different trust legacy.

Many considered the police investigations to have been procedurally unfair. Confessions were extracted under duress and 77 of the 96 convicted men were executed, a rate that suggests that the proceedings prioritized deterrence over careful adjudication (Pratten, 2007). There is a case of visible punishment rather than of a procedurally fair process. A finding of durable positive attitudes toward courts would indicate that instrumental effectiveness can build trust without procedural fairness. This intervention also differs from purely extractive colonial policing in that it responded to a pre-existing community crisis.

### 3. Theoretical Framework

#### 3.1. Legitimacy, Trust, and Institutional Performance

Two accounts of institutional legitimacy compete in the literature. The *procedural justice* model, developed primarily in Western democracies, holds that citizens grant legitimacy to legal authorities based on the perceived fairness of the processes through which those authorities exercise power: respectful treatment, voice, and neutral decision-making (Tyler, 2006; Sunshine and Tyler, 2003; Hough et al., 2010; Jackson et al., 2012). The *instrumental*

*legitimacy* model holds instead that citizens evaluate institutions based on outcomes — whether police effectively control crime, whether courts deliver convictions, whether the state resolves threats that communities cannot resolve on their own (Tankebe, 2009, 2008). Where citizens face high baseline insecurity and the formal state is the only actor with the coercive capacity to restore order, instrumental performance should plausibly carry more weight than procedural form.

The empirical literature on African policing supports the instrumental account. Trust in police across sub-Saharan African settings tracks perceptions of effectiveness more closely than perceptions of fairness (Tankebe, 2009; Akinlabi, 2018), and in Nigeria specifically, perceptions of police effectiveness predict legitimacy judgments more strongly than perceptions of procedural justice (Akinlabi, 2022a). We assume that this should also apply to the case in this paper. The procedural model is a competing explanation for our study that predicts at most a null or negative legacy. A finding of durable positive trust in courts in our case is therefore a hard test of the instrumental account against the procedural one. The case allows us to distinguish two further mechanisms within the instrumental family: the police investigation generated trust through visible coercive presence, while the court process generated trust through the public delivery of resolution (trial, conviction, and execution of named perpetrators). We expect the latter to produce a more durable legacy than the former.

*H1 (Police Trust): Individuals currently residing in areas affected by the Man Leopard investigation will exhibit higher levels of trust in the Nigerian police than individuals in comparable but unaffected areas.*

*H2 (Courts Trust): Individuals currently residing in areas where the Man Leopard perpetrators were tried, convicted, and executed will exhibit higher levels of trust in courts than individuals in comparable areas, reflecting the visible resolution delivered by the judicial process.*

Trust in police and trust in courts follow different mechanisms. Trust in police is shaped

by frequent, often involuntary personal encounters, which leaves it open to updating through lived experience. Negative encounters erode trust more than positive encounters build it (the asymmetry thesis), and people with higher baseline trust update downward more dramatically after negative contact (Oliveira et al., 2021). In Nigeria, this dynamic produces an institutional distrust trap in which pervasive distrust drives police toward coercive practices that further undermine trust (Tiwa, 2024). Trust in courts operates less through personal contact (most citizens rarely interact with courts directly) and more through diffuse institutional evaluations. Exposure to legal symbols and procedures reinforces institutional loyalty through a positive bias (Gibson and Caldeira, 2009). We expect trust in courts to be more resistant to erosion and more amenable to intergenerational transmission through community memory.

*H3 (Conditional Effect): Any positive trust legacy in police will be attenuated or eliminated by negative contemporary police contact, consistent with the asymmetry thesis that trust is “hard to win, easy to lose.”*

### 3.2. Colonial Legacies and Intergenerational Transmission

Extractive colonial institutions generate persistent negative outcomes (Acemoglu et al., 2001; Dell, 2010), and colonial security investments can produce lasting organizational capacity (Eck, 2018). We examine a complementary channel: whether effective colonial justice provision also built durable community *trust*. Institutional investments persist through bureaucratic inertia; trust requires active reproduction through ongoing social processes (Acharya et al., 2016). Colonial medical campaigns in Central Africa *reduced* trust in health institutions for decades, with domain-specific effects that do not extend to other institutions (Lowes and Montero, 2021). The Man Leopard response, in contrast, addressed a community’s existing security threat rather than imposing an unwanted intervention.

Attitudes formed in response to historical events can persist across generations through cultural transmission. For example, individuals whose ancestors experienced heavy slave

raids are less trusting today (Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011). Descendants of deported Crimean Tatars have more hostile attitudes toward Russia, with domain-specific effects (Lupu and Peisakhin, 2017). However, for such legacy to endure, they must be actively reproduced through ongoing social processes (Acharya et al., 2016).

Ethnographic evidence from the former leopard area documents these transmission channels. The story of the murders has circulated since the investigations, captured in a song still known locally: “Ikot Afanga, *idúń ẹkpẹ ọwọ*” (Ikot Afanga, the village of the leopard men), and the path leading to Ikot Okoro is still known as the “man-leopard road” (Pratten, 2007, pp. 340–341). Memory transmission follows gendered lines: women, especially younger women in Pentecostal congregations, deny knowledge of the murders and at times actively prevent male relatives from passing on their own recollections, while young men are more likely to reconstruct than to reject stories of the leopard men (Pratten, 2007, pp. 341–342).

## 4. Data and Methods

### 4.1. Data

Our primary data source is the Afrobarometer survey (rounds 3–9) for Nigeria, which includes geolocated interview coordinates (BenYishay et al., 2017), trust measures for multiple institutions, police contact questions, and respondents’ self-reported ethnic identification. We employ two main dependent variables. *Trust in police* is measured through the question: “How much do you trust the police?” *Trust in courts* is measured through: “How much do you trust courts of law?” Both are coded on a four-point scale from “not at all” to “a lot,” which we dichotomize (1 = any trust, 0 = not at all) for our main specifications. These two outcomes correspond to the two institutional channels of the Man Leopard response: the police investigation and the court trial. As placebo outcomes, we use six additional trust measures available across all rounds: trust in the president, parliament, the electoral commission, local government, the ruling party, and the opposition.

## 4.2. Treatment Definitions

We employ three empirical specifications with progressively broader control groups:

**Specification 1: Man Leopard Region vs. Rest of Calabar Province.** This compares the affected murder zone to other areas within the Calabar Province, providing the tightest geographic comparison but with limited statistical power (treatment  $N = 16$ , control  $N = 648$ ). While this seems like the obvious choice, the lack of power limits the inferential capabilities of any of our estimates.

**Specification 2: Calabar Province vs. South East (SE) Region.** This compares Calabar Province to other South East states (Abia, Anambra, Akwa Ibom [non-Calabar portions], Bayelsa, Cross River [non-Calabar], Ebonyi, Enugu, Imo, Rivers [non-Calabar]) which were part of the former Eastern Region. The former Calabar Province corresponds in contemporary administrative terms to most of present-day Akwa Ibom State, parts of Cross River State, and Arochuku Local Government Area in Abia State. This provides greater statistical power (treatment  $N = 664$ , control  $N = 2,801$ ) while reducing confounding from North-South divisions, Christian-Muslim differences, and colonial administrative variations. Ethnic group fixed effects absorb ethnolinguistic differences across the region’s diverse populations (Igbo, Ijaw, Ibibio/Annang, and others). This is our preferred specification. We use this specification on the assumption that the treatment of experiencing the police investigation and the court proceedings were spread across the province through the publications of the Nigerian Eastern Mail. [Pratten \(2007\)](#) documents that this news paper, based in the City of Calabar, was instrumental for disseminating information about the investigations, trials, and subsequent hangings of perpetrators of the murders.

**Specification 3: Calabar Province vs. Whole Country.** Our last specification compares Calabar Province to the rest of Nigeria (treatment  $N = 664$ , control  $N = 13,612$ ), maximizing power at the cost of confounding from Nigeria’s regional heterogeneity.

Following the historical descriptions in [Pratten \(2007\)](#), we geo-reference the Man Leopard boundaries and map them to areas in contemporary Nigeria. Figure 1 presents the treatment



Figure 1: Map of Nigeria showing the former Eastern region, Calabar Province, and the Man Leopard zone in diminishing progression. The largest, outlined in black, marks the former Eastern region. A smaller polygon outlined in red within it marks the former Calabar Province. The smallest circular polygon outlined in purple inside the Calabar Province marks the Man Leopard murder zone.

and control areas for each specification. The largest polygon outlined in black shows the former Eastern region of Nigeria. The red outlined within the South Eastern region, polygon shows the boundaries for the former Calabar Province. The circled boundary in purple shows the extent of the Man Leopard zone.

#### 4.3. Identification and Alternative Explanations

Our baseline specification takes the form:

$$Trust_i = \alpha + \beta \cdot Treatment_i + X_i\gamma + \delta_e + \delta_r + \varepsilon_i \quad (1)$$

where  $Trust_i$  is trust in the police or courts for individual  $i$ ,  $Treatment_i$  indicates treatment

status (varying by specification),  $X_i$  is a vector of individual-level controls (age, gender, education, urban residence, employment),  $\delta_e$  represents ethnic group fixed effects,  $\delta_r$  represents survey round fixed effects, and  $\varepsilon_i$  is the error term clustered at the ethnic group level.

We do not claim strict causal identification. The murders occurred in areas where the Ekpe secret societies were strong, economic conditions were deteriorating, and colonial administration was weak; these pre-treatment conditions could independently affect contemporary trust. We interpret our results as informative associations, supported by robustness checks that probe sensitivity to control group selection, migration composition, civil war confounding, and unobserved confounding.

An alternative explanation for our results is that Calabar Province held a privileged position in the colonial administrative system that left a generalized trust legacy unrelated to the Man Leopard events. Calabar city served as the capital of the Eastern Region until 1939 and was an early site of colonial commercial, missionary, and bureaucratic activity. If proximity to colonial administrative capacity is what shapes contemporary trust in formal institutions, the Calabar coefficient might be picking up that exposure rather than anything specific to the leopard trials. We argue against this explanation for 3 reasons. Firstly, the murders and the police intervention concentrated in the rural Abak and Opobo districts, which were geographically and administratively distant from Calabar city; the treatment effect we estimate is at the level of the former Calabar Province, not at the level of proximity to Calabar city. Secondly, the South East control region itself contained another colonial administrative capital — Enugu, which was the successor capital of the former Eastern Region from 1939 onward, so the comparison is not between a colonial-capital province and a region without one. Thirdly, and most diagnostically, the colonial-capacity story predicts elevated Calabar trust across formal institutions, while our placebo tests show that the trust premium is confined to courts and does not extend to the president, parliament, the electoral commission, local government, the ruling party, or the opposition. The pattern is domain-specific in a way that a generalized colonial-capacity legacy cannot easily reproduce.

Two further alternatives are worth noting. Both the treatment and control areas were part of the secessionist Republic of Biafra (1967–1970); we address this by excluding war-affected cohorts and testing for treatment-by-civil-war-cohort interactions. Cross-sectional legacy comparisons can also be confounded by selective sorting (Marbach, 2024). We classify respondents as “stayers” or “migrants” by matching self-reported ethnicity to historically known home states and implement interactions, stayers-only, and decomposition analyses. Our contact moderators (bribe-paying and difficulty accessing police help) were selected *ex ante* based on the asymmetry thesis.

#### 4.4. Summary Statistics

Table 1 presents summary statistics across the four geographic groups.

Table 1: Summary Statistics by Geographic Group

|                         | Man Leopard<br>( $N = 16$ ) | Rest of Calabar<br>( $N = 648$ ) | SE Region<br>( $N = 2,801$ ) | Rest of Country<br>( $N = 10,811$ ) |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Age                     | 35.1                        | 42.5                             | 32.7                         | 35.6                                |
| Female (%)              | 50.0                        | 50.2                             | 50.2                         | 49.9                                |
| Education               | 9.81                        | 4.99                             | 5.28                         | 4.29                                |
| Urban (%)               | 0.0                         | 24.7                             | 51.3                         | 45.2                                |
| Trust in Police         | 0.688                       | 0.370                            | 0.341                        | 0.533                               |
| Trust in Courts         | 0.812                       | 0.733                            | 0.632                        | 0.781                               |
| Paid Bribe to Police    | 0.500                       | 0.410                            | 0.356                        | 0.332                               |
| Difficulty Getting Help | 0.000                       | 0.101                            | 0.087                        | 0.120                               |

*Notes:* Data from Afrobarometer rounds 3–9. Trust, Bribe, and Difficulty are binary indicators. Education is an ordinal scale. The Man Leopard zone is the core area affected by the murders within Calabar Province. “Rest of Calabar” comprises the remainder of the province. “SE Region” includes other South East states (Abia, Anambra, Akwa Ibom, Bayelsa, Cross River, Ebonyi, Enugu, Imo, Rivers) excluding Calabar Province. Calabar respondents are older, less urban, and report higher rates of bribe-paying to police than SE counterparts.

The baseline differences between the four groups are visible in the descriptive statistics. The Man Leopard zone respondents report the highest trust in both police and courts, although the small sample ( $N = 16$ ) limits inference. Trust in courts for respondents living in Calabar exceeds the SE Region average by about ten percentage points, while trust in

police is comparable across the two. Calabar respondents are on average older, less urban, and more likely to report paying bribes to police. These differences motivate the inclusion of individual-level controls and ethnic group fixed effects.

## 5. Results

### 5.1. Baseline Results

We present results for H1 and H2 in this section first. Table 2 presents baseline results for trust in police (Panel A) and trust in courts (Panel B) in treatment-control specifications 2 and 3. All models include ethnic group, and survey round fixed effects, we also include individual-level controls in some specifications. The results of Specification 1 (Man Leopard zone vs. rest of Calabar Province,  $N_{treatment} = 16$ ) are presented in Appendix Table A1; we discuss that specification only briefly here because the very small treatment group severely limits statistical power.

| Table 2: Baseline Results: Trust in Police and Trust in Courts |                       |                     |                     |                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|---------------------|--------------------|
|                                                                | Calabar vs. SE Region |                     | Calabar vs. Country |                    |
|                                                                | (1)                   | (2)                 | (3)                 | (4)                |
| <i>Panel A: Trust in Police</i>                                |                       |                     |                     |                    |
| Calabar                                                        | −0.050<br>(0.049)     | −0.044<br>(0.048)   | −0.130<br>(0.078)   | −0.134*<br>(0.080) |
| Observations                                                   | 3,415                 | 3,415               | 14,075              | 14,075             |
| R <sup>2</sup>                                                 | 0.037                 | 0.039               | 0.110               | 0.111              |
| <i>Panel B: Trust in Courts</i>                                |                       |                     |                     |                    |
| Calabar                                                        | 0.062***<br>(0.021)   | 0.078***<br>(0.021) | −0.013<br>(0.046)   | −0.010<br>(0.047)  |
| Observations                                                   | 3,390                 | 3,390               | 13,909              | 13,909             |
| R <sup>2</sup>                                                 | 0.082                 | 0.088               | 0.065               | 0.066              |
| Ethnic group FE                                                | Yes                   | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes                |
| Round FE                                                       | Yes                   | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes                |
| Individual controls                                            | No                    | Yes                 | No                  | Yes                |

Standard errors clustered by ethnic group in parentheses. Individual controls: age, gender, employment, education, religion, urban/rural. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

For *trust in police* (Panel A), the Specification 2 results (Calabar vs. SE Region) is close to zero and insignificant. In Specification 3 (Calabar vs. whole country), the estimate is weakly negative. Specification 1 in the appendix yields a positive coefficient for the Man Leopard zone, indicating a trust in police premium confined to the immediate affected area; the treatment group of 16 respondents limits the reliability of that result.

The *trust in the courts* (Panel B) shows that Calabar province residents report higher trust than SE region residents (Specification 2). The effect holds with and without individual controls. The premium is attenuated to close to zero in the comparison between residents of Calabar province and the rest of the country (Specification 3).

These divergent results map onto the two institutional channels of the response. The police investigation concentrated in the immediate affected zone and produced a trust advantage that does not extend beyond it. The court trial, conviction, and execution of the perpetrators took place at the provincial level as a public event, and the province-wide trust advantage for courts corresponds to that scale.

## 5.2. Placebo Tests

Table 3 examines whether the trust in courts effect is domain-specific. Following [Lowes and Montero \(2021\)](#)'s argument, if the Man Leopard events uniquely shaped attitudes toward justice institutions, we should not observe effects on trust in other state institutions.

Table 3: Placebo Tests: Trust in Other Institutions (Calabar vs. SE Region)

|                     | President<br>(1)  | Parliament<br>(2) | Elec. Com.<br>(3) | Local Gov.<br>(4) | Ruling Party<br>(5) | Opposition<br>(6) |
|---------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|---------------------|-------------------|
| Calabar             | -0.013<br>(0.049) | 0.009<br>(0.035)  | 0.009<br>(0.030)  | 0.017<br>(0.035)  | -0.028<br>(0.041)   | 0.028<br>(0.039)  |
| Ethnic group FE     | Yes               | Yes               | Yes               | Yes               | Yes                 | Yes               |
| Round FE            | Yes               | Yes               | Yes               | Yes               | Yes                 | Yes               |
| Individual controls | Yes               | Yes               | Yes               | Yes               | Yes                 | Yes               |
| Observations        | 3,392             | 3,368             | 3,386             | 3,373             | 3,363               | 3,301             |
| R <sup>2</sup>      | 0.236             | 0.111             | 0.113             | 0.066             | 0.112               | 0.065             |

Outcomes are binary trust indicators for six other state institutions. All specifications include individual controls (age, gender, employment, education, religion, urban/rural). Standard errors clustered by ethnic group in parentheses. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

The placebo tests support domain specificity. The Calabar coefficient is close to zero and insignificant for all six placebo outcomes: trust in the president, parliament, the electoral commission, local government, the ruling party and the opposition. The results rule out an interpretation in which Calabar residents express higher trust in state institutions generally. The trust in court advantage is specific to the institution whose historical performance (the trial and execution of Man Leopard perpetrators) provides a mechanism for attitudinal persistence.

### 5.3. Cohort Analysis

Table 4 interacts the treatment with birth cohort dummies (reference: 1990s+) for trust in police (Panel A) and trust in courts (Panel B). If the Man Leopard events generated persistent trust through intergenerational transmission, we might expect differential effects across cohorts (Acharya et al., 2016).

Table 4: Cohort Analysis: Trust in Police and Trust in Courts

|                                 | Calabar vs. SE Region |                     | Calabar vs. Country  |                      |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
|                                 | (1)                   | (2)                 | (3)                  | (4)                  |
| <i>Panel A: Trust in Police</i> |                       |                     |                      |                      |
| Calabar                         | -0.143**<br>(0.059)   | -0.126**<br>(0.062) | -0.247***<br>(0.055) | -0.251***<br>(0.056) |
| Calabar × pre-1940s             | 0.153***<br>(0.046)   | -0.222*<br>(0.127)  | 0.220***<br>(0.047)  | 0.143<br>(0.105)     |
| Calabar × 1940s                 | 0.105<br>(0.186)      | 0.078<br>(0.188)    | 0.130<br>(0.196)     | 0.119<br>(0.199)     |
| Calabar × 1950s                 | 0.153<br>(0.129)      | 0.130<br>(0.134)    | 0.177<br>(0.139)     | 0.170<br>(0.140)     |
| Calabar × 1960s                 | 0.114<br>(0.131)      | 0.094<br>(0.133)    | 0.144<br>(0.136)     | 0.141<br>(0.138)     |
| Calabar × 1970s                 | 0.133**<br>(0.049)    | 0.119**<br>(0.052)  | 0.177***<br>(0.046)  | 0.177***<br>(0.047)  |
| Calabar × 1980s                 | 0.131**<br>(0.062)    | 0.124*<br>(0.064)   | 0.175***<br>(0.063)  | 0.175***<br>(0.062)  |
| Observations                    | 3,415                 | 3,415               | 14,075               | 14,075               |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.039                 | 0.042               | 0.111                | 0.112                |
| <i>Panel B: Trust in Courts</i> |                       |                     |                      |                      |
| Calabar                         | 0.023<br>(0.022)      | 0.051**<br>(0.020)  | -0.089<br>(0.053)    | -0.084<br>(0.056)    |
| Calabar × pre-1940s             | 0.134<br>(0.104)      | -0.080<br>(0.072)   | 0.206*<br>(0.108)    | 0.207<br>(0.128)     |
| Calabar × 1940s                 | 0.256***<br>(0.041)   | 0.232***<br>(0.046) | 0.326***<br>(0.040)  | 0.322***<br>(0.043)  |
| Calabar × 1950s                 | -0.010<br>(0.083)     | -0.034<br>(0.076)   | 0.025<br>(0.093)     | 0.020<br>(0.093)     |
| Calabar × 1960s                 | 0.106<br>(0.068)      | 0.089<br>(0.069)    | 0.148**<br>(0.067)   | 0.148**<br>(0.067)   |
| Calabar × 1970s                 | 0.021<br>(0.034)      | -0.001<br>(0.038)   | 0.081*<br>(0.042)    | 0.079*<br>(0.045)    |
| Calabar × 1980s                 | 0.070**<br>(0.028)    | 0.059*<br>(0.029)   | 0.128***<br>(0.040)  | 0.127***<br>(0.041)  |
| Observations                    | 3,390                 | 3,390               | 13,909               | 13,909               |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.083                 | 0.090               | 0.066                | 0.067                |
| Ethnic group FE                 | Yes                   | Yes                 | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| Round FE                        | Yes                   | Yes                 | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| Individual controls             | No                    | Yes                 | No                   | Yes                  |

Reference cohort: 1990s and later. Standard errors clustered by ethnic group in parentheses. Individual controls: age, gender, employment, education, religion, urban/rural.  
 \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

The results for trust in police (Panel A), the Calabar base effect in Specification 2 is negative, and the 1970s and 1980s cohort interactions are positive and insignificant. Younger cohorts in Calabar report higher trust in police than their SE counterparts. For trust in courts (Panel B), the 1940s cohort interaction in Specification 2 is large and insignificant, consistent with transmission from the generation closest to the Man Leopard trials. The 1980s cohort interaction is also positive and significant at conventional levels. The base Calabar effect with controls remains positive, and the trust in courts advantage holds among the youngest cohort. The 1980s cohort effect for trust in courts has no obvious historical explanation. It may reflect cohort-specific experiences with Nigeria's judicial system during

the post-military transition of the late 1990s and 2000s, when this cohort came of age, or it may be a statistical artifact given the cell sizes. We flag it for transparency and do not build interpretive weight on it.

#### 5.4. Migration Analysis

Table 5 addresses migration bias through decomposition by stayer/migrant status, with trust in police in Panel A and trust in courts in Panel B. The migration analysis addresses the selective sorting concern raised in Marbach (2024). In the full-sample interaction models (columns 1–2), stayers report higher trust in police than migrants, and the Calabar  $\times$  stayers interaction is close to zero. The null police result does not vary by migration status. For trust in courts, the stayers-only subsample (columns 3–4) yields a positive and significant Calabar effect, while the migrants-only estimate (column 5) is larger though insignificant. The trust in courts advantage concentrates among individuals whose families have remained in the region across generations, consistent with intergenerational transmission of attitudes rooted in the trials. The Calabar  $\times$  stayers interaction for trust in courts is positive and insignificant in the full-sample model.

Table 5: Migration Analysis (Calabar vs. SE Region): Trust in Police and Trust in Courts

|                                 | Full Sample       |                    | Stayers Only       |                    | Migrants Only     |
|---------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------|--------------------|--------------------|-------------------|
|                                 | (1)               | (2)                | (3)                | (4)                | (5)               |
| <i>Panel A: Trust in Police</i> |                   |                    |                    |                    |                   |
| Calabar                         | −0.046<br>(0.042) | −0.035<br>(0.044)  | −0.084<br>(0.066)  | −0.080<br>(0.064)  | −0.033<br>(0.054) |
| Stayers                         | 0.107*<br>(0.057) | 0.113**<br>(0.055) |                    |                    |                   |
| Calabar × Stayers               | −0.033<br>(0.066) | −0.040<br>(0.065)  |                    |                    |                   |
| Observations                    | 3,415             | 3,415              | 2,885              | 2,885              | 530               |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.038             | 0.040              | 0.039              | 0.040              | 0.070             |
| <i>Panel B: Trust in Courts</i> |                   |                    |                    |                    |                   |
| Calabar                         | 0.022<br>(0.066)  | 0.045<br>(0.060)   | 0.059**<br>(0.024) | 0.067**<br>(0.026) | 0.075<br>(0.046)  |
| Stayers                         | −0.041<br>(0.048) | −0.029<br>(0.052)  |                    |                    |                   |
| Calabar × Stayers               | 0.076<br>(0.071)  | 0.061<br>(0.065)   |                    |                    |                   |
| Observations                    | 3,390             | 3,390              | 2,862              | 2,862              | 528               |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.082             | 0.089              | 0.067              | 0.073              | 0.213             |
| Ethnic group FE                 | Yes               | Yes                | Yes                | Yes                | Yes               |
| Round FE                        | Yes               | Yes                | Yes                | Yes                | Yes               |
| Individual controls             | No                | Yes                | No                 | Yes                | Yes               |

Stayers: respondents whose self-reported ethnicity matches the historical ethnic homeland (Murdock 1959) for their current location. Standard errors clustered by ethnic group in parentheses. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

### 5.5. Contact Mechanisms and the Asymmetry Thesis

We now turn to our test of H3. Because Afrobarometer asks no questions about respondents' contact with courts (no analogue to the police bribe-paying or difficulty-accessing-help items appears in any round), we cannot construct a comparable contact-based analysis for trust in courts. The asymmetry thesis test is therefore limited to the police outcome. Table 6 interacts the Calabar treatment with two measures of police contact (bribe-paying and difficulty accessing police help) and presents subsample results for respondents with and without each type of contact.

Table 6: Contact Mechanism (Trust in Police, Calabar vs. SE Region)

|                             | Bribe-Paying        |                     |                  |                   | Difficulty Accessing Help |                      |                  |                   |
|-----------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|------------------|-------------------|---------------------------|----------------------|------------------|-------------------|
|                             | Interaction         |                     | Bribe=1          | No Bribe          | Interaction               |                      | Diff.=1          | No Diff.          |
|                             | (1)                 | (2)                 | (3)              | (4)               | (5)                       | (6)                  | (7)              | (8)               |
| Calabar                     | 0.022<br>(0.102)    | 0.020<br>(0.099)    | 0.065<br>(0.068) | -0.022<br>(0.104) | -0.016<br>(0.088)         | -0.010<br>(0.085)    | 0.042<br>(0.085) | -0.010<br>(0.091) |
| Bribe                       | 0.059***<br>(0.017) | 0.054***<br>(0.019) |                  |                   |                           |                      |                  |                   |
| Calabar $\times$ Bribe      | -0.064<br>(0.044)   | -0.051<br>(0.046)   |                  |                   |                           |                      |                  |                   |
| Difficulty                  |                     |                     |                  |                   | 0.033<br>(0.041)          | 0.028<br>(0.038)     |                  |                   |
| Calabar $\times$ Difficulty |                     |                     |                  |                   | -0.115***<br>(0.036)      | -0.108***<br>(0.037) |                  |                   |
| Ethnic group FE             | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes              | Yes               | Yes                       | Yes                  | Yes              | Yes               |
| Round FE                    | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes              | Yes               | Yes                       | Yes                  | Yes              | Yes               |
| Individual controls         | No                  | Yes                 | Yes              | Yes               | No                        | Yes                  | Yes              | Yes               |
| Observations                | 1,754               | 1,754               | 646              | 1,108             | 986                       | 986                  | 88               | 898               |
| R <sup>2</sup>              | 0.044               | 0.047               | 0.106            | 0.048             | 0.074                     | 0.081                | 0.270            | 0.083             |

Outcome: trust in police. Columns (1)–(4): bribe-paying moderator. Columns (5)–(8): difficulty accessing police help. Standard errors clustered by ethnic group in parentheses. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

The Calabar  $\times$  bribe interaction (columns 1–2) is negative and insignificant. The subsample decomposition (columns 3–4) shows that among bribe-payers, Calabar respondents report slightly higher trust in police than their SE counterparts, while among non-bribe-payers the Calabar effect is slightly negative. Neither subsample result is distinguishable from zero. Bribe-paying does not moderate the treatment-trust relationship.

The difficulty measure shows different results however. The Calabar  $\times$  Difficulty interaction (columns 5–6) is negative, large, and insignificant: among the respondents who reported difficulty getting help from the police, Calabar residents reported lower trust than their SE counterparts. The subsample analysis shows that among respondents who experienced difficulty (column 7,  $N = 88$ ), the Calabar estimate is positive and insignificant, while among those who did not (column 8) the effect is near zero. This is consistent with H3 and the asymmetry thesis (Oliveira et al., 2021). A baseline expectation of police responsiveness, rooted in historical experience, makes contemporary failure more trust-depleting.

## 5.6. Heterogeneity

Table 7 examines whether the trust effects vary across demographic subgroups by interacting the Calabar treatment with gender, urban/rural residence, education, and employment, for trust in police (Panel A) and trust in courts (Panel B).

Table 7: Heterogeneity in the Trust Effects (Calabar vs. SE)

|                                 | Gender<br>(1)       | Urban/Rural<br>(2) | Education<br>(3)    | Employment<br>(4)  |
|---------------------------------|---------------------|--------------------|---------------------|--------------------|
| <i>Panel A: Trust in Police</i> |                     |                    |                     |                    |
| Calabar                         | -0.070<br>(0.054)   | -0.158*<br>(0.090) | -0.061<br>(0.054)   | -0.065<br>(0.061)  |
| Calabar $\times$ Gender         | 0.018<br>(0.016)    |                    |                     |                    |
| Calabar $\times$ Urb/Rur        |                     | 0.066*<br>(0.037)  |                     |                    |
| Calabar $\times$ Education      |                     |                    | 0.003<br>(0.003)    |                    |
| Calabar $\times$ Employment     |                     |                    |                     | 0.014<br>(0.015)   |
| Observations                    | 3,415               | 3,415              | 3,415               | 3,415              |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.039               | 0.039              | 0.039               | 0.039              |
| <i>Panel B: Trust in Courts</i> |                     |                    |                     |                    |
| Calabar                         | 0.129***<br>(0.038) | -0.056<br>(0.080)  | 0.080***<br>(0.019) | 0.068**<br>(0.028) |
| Calabar $\times$ Gender         | -0.034**<br>(0.014) |                    |                     |                    |
| Calabar $\times$ Urb/Rur        |                     | 0.078*<br>(0.040)  |                     |                    |
| Calabar $\times$ Education      |                     |                    | -0.000<br>(0.002)   |                    |
| Calabar $\times$ Employment     |                     |                    |                     | 0.007<br>(0.014)   |
| Observations                    | 3,390               | 3,390              | 3,390               | 3,390              |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.089               | 0.089              | 0.088               | 0.088              |
| Ethnic group FE                 | Yes                 | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                |
| Round FE                        | Yes                 | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                |
| Individual controls             | Yes                 | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                |

Gender: female = 1. Urban/Rural: urban = 1. Standard errors clustered by ethnic group in parentheses. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

The police panel does not provide evidence of gender, education, or employment moderation. The Calabar  $\times$  Urban/Rural interaction is positive and marginally significant. For courts, the Calabar  $\times$  Gender interaction is negative and insignificant: trust in courts advantage is concentrated among men and attenuates for women. This matches the ethnographic

record of gendered memory transmission, in which women suppress their engagement with the past while men reconstruct and circulate the narratives (Pratten, 2007, pp. 341–342). The gendered asymmetry in narrative engagement predicts the gendered asymmetry in the trust effect. The Calabar  $\times$  Urban/Rural interaction for courts is also positive and marginally significant. Education and employment do not moderate either effect.

### 5.7. Robustness Checks

The treatment and control areas were part of the secessionist Republic of Biafra. We test whether differential war experiences drive the results. In the appendix (Tables 8a–8d) we exclude 1960s–1970s birth cohorts, interact the treatment with a civil war cohort indicator, and restrict to stayers among non-war cohorts. The Calabar  $\times$  civil war cohort interaction is close to zero and insignificant for both outcomes, and trust in the court advantage is stable across all specifications. The Civil War does not account for the main findings.

Our main analyses dichotomize the original four-category Afrobarometer trust measure (0 = “not at all,” 1 = “just a little,” 2 = “somewhat,” 3 = “a lot”) into a binary indicator. Table 8 presents results using the full ordinal measure as the dependent variable, estimated via OLS with ethnic group and survey round fixed effects, for trust in police (Panel A) and trust in courts (Panel B).

Table 8: Robustness: OLS on Ordinal Trust Scale (0–3)

|                                 | Calabar vs. SE Region |                     | Calabar vs. Country |                   |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|---------------------|-------------------|
|                                 | (1)                   | (2)                 | (3)                 | (4)               |
| <i>Panel A: Trust in Police</i> |                       |                     |                     |                   |
| Calabar                         | −0.032<br>(0.062)     | −0.020<br>(0.061)   | −0.172<br>(0.129)   | −0.179<br>(0.131) |
| Observations                    | 3,415                 | 3,415               | 14,075              | 14,075            |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.039                 | 0.042               | 0.108               | 0.109             |
| <i>Panel B: Trust in Courts</i> |                       |                     |                     |                   |
| Calabar                         | 0.189***<br>(0.050)   | 0.212***<br>(0.051) | 0.038<br>(0.110)    | 0.045<br>(0.113)  |
| Observations                    | 3,390                 | 3,390               | 13,909              | 13,909            |
| R <sup>2</sup>                  | 0.076                 | 0.081               | 0.071               | 0.072             |
| Ethnic group FE                 | Yes                   | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes               |
| Round FE                        | Yes                   | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes               |
| Individual controls             | No                    | Yes                 | No                  | Yes               |

Dependent variable: original four-category Afrobarometer trust scale (0 = not at all, 3 = a lot). Man Leopard zone specification is reported in Appendix Table A7. Standard errors clustered by ethnic group in parentheses. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

The ordinal and binary specifications show similar results. For trust in police (Panel A), the Calabar coefficient in the preferred specification is close to zero. For trust in courts (Panel B), the ordinal specification yields a positive and significant Calabar effect: Calabar residents report higher trust in courts across the full four-point scale. Ordered logit models with state fixed effects yield similar conclusions (Appendix Tables 7c–7d). The main findings are not an artifact of the dichotomization threshold.

Because the design is observational, and there is a 60–80 year gap between the treatment and our observed outcomes, we assess the robustness of the trust in courts finding to omitted variable bias using the framework in [Cinelli and Hazlett \(2020\)](#). They asks how strong an unobserved confounder would need to be, in its association with both treatment and outcome, to explain away the estimated effect.

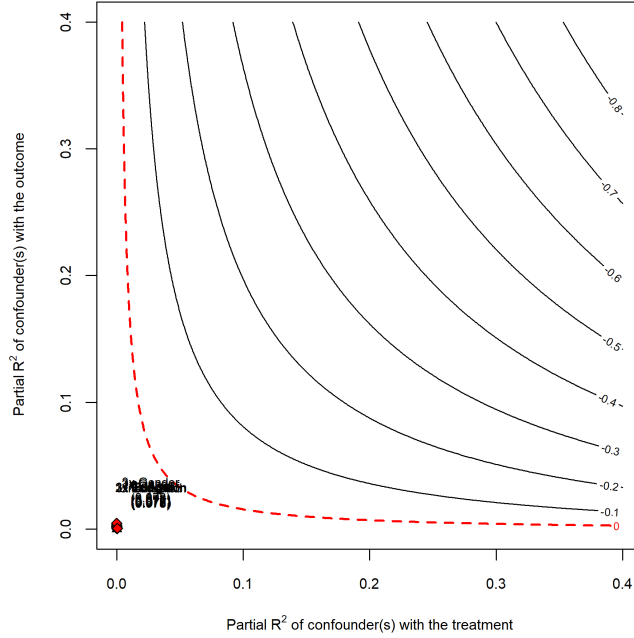


Figure 2: Sensitivity contour plot for trust in courts (Calabar vs. SE). The red diamond marks the unadjusted estimate. Contours show adjusted estimates under varying strengths of hypothetical confounders. Benchmark points indicate the explanatory power of observed covariates (Age, Gender, Education) at 1x, 2x, and 3x their observed strength.

Figure 2 presents the sensitivity contour plot. The robustness value is 4.1 percent: an unobserved confounder would need to explain more than 4.1 percent of the residual variance of both Calabar treatment status and trust in courts to reduce the point estimate to zero. A confounder three times as strong as Age, Gender, or Education in its association with both treatment and outcome would leave the estimate close to its original value. Adjusted point estimates remain positive and distinguishable from zero across all benchmarked scenarios. The robustness value for statistical significance is 0.8 percent, and no observed covariate approaches that threshold. An unobserved confounder capable of explaining away the result would need to be stronger than any individual demographic characteristic in the data.

## 6. Discussion and Conclusion

This paper examines whether effective colonial justice provision can generate durable community trust in post-colonial institutions. The Man Leopard murders offer a case in which two components of the colonial justice system, police investigation, and court adjudication, were deployed against a community security threat, and allow us to study whether the two institutional channels produce different attitudinal legacies.

The court process left a more durable imprint than the police investigation. Calabar Province residents report higher trust in courts than SE Region residents, the effect is specific to courts (all six placebo trust outcomes are null), and it concentrates among cohorts closest to the events. Trust in police is elevated only within the Man Leopard zone and does not extend to the broader province. The two institutions operated through different mechanisms. The investigation was coercive and localized, saturating the affected area with officers under a nuisance policy. The court trial, conviction, and execution of 77 perpetrators produced a visible resolution across the province. Public judicial outcomes carry through the community memory further than the temporary and geographically bounded police presence.

The heterogeneity analysis provides a second line of evidence for narrative transmission. The trust in courts advantage is stronger among men. Our results match the ethnographic record of gendered memory transmission in the former leopard area, where women suppress the events and men reconstruct and circulate the narratives ([Pratten, 2007](#), pp. 341–342). Qualitative evidence on gendered memory and quantitative evidence on gendered trust effects point to the same narrative channel.

The contact analysis adds a third line. Calabar respondents who report difficulty accessing police help experience a larger trust penalty than comparable respondents elsewhere, consistent with the asymmetry thesis ([Oliveira et al., 2021](#)): a historically grounded expectation of police responsiveness makes contemporary failure more trust-depleting. The Afrobarometer does not include court-contact items, so we cannot run the parallel test for

courts. The institutional specificity of the courts result points to a different channel, one rooted in collective memory of judicial resolution rather than personal experience of court contact.

Alternative explanations face some constraints. Any confounder that accounts for the trust in courts finding would need to affect trust in courts but not trust in police, the president, parliament, the electoral commission, local government, the ruling party, or the opposition (six null placebos); operate at the Calabar Province level rather than within the Man Leopard zone specifically; be stronger among men than women; concentrate among stayers rather than migrants; peak in the 1940s birth cohort; and be orthogonal to the Nigerian Civil War (the interaction is null). The colonial capital story fails on domain specificity: it would predict elevated trust across institutions. Ethnic composition is absorbed by the fixed effects. A Civil War story fails on the cohort interaction test. The gender moderation is difficult to reconcile with any account that does not involve the gendered Man Leopard events. The sensitivity analysis shows that even a confounder several times as strong as any observed covariate would not eliminate the trust in courts finding.

These findings speak to three strands of the literature. They extend the institutional account in [Eck \(2018\)](#) by showing that different components of the justice system generate different attitudinal legacies. Colonial security investments produce lasting organizational capacity ([Eck, 2018](#)); the adjudicative dimension of the justice system, which delivers visible resolution through trial and punishment, also produces durable public trust. The literature on colonial legacies has documented domain-specific negative legacy ([Lowes and Montero, 2021](#)); the Man Leopard case adds a domain-specific positive legacy, generated when the colonial intervention addressed a community threat.

The results also speak to the transitional justice literature on trials, tribunals, and truth commissions ([Gibson, 2006](#); [Sikkink, 2011](#); [Zvobgo, 2020](#)). The Man Leopard case is not a canonical transitional justice episode, but it shares structural features with that class of events: widespread violence, state-led investigation, public trials, and visible punishment.

The literature debates whether retributive or restorative responses rebuild trust more effectively ([Mendeloff, 2004](#); [Olsen et al., 2010](#); [Zvobgo, 2026](#)). The court trial generated a more durable trust legacy than the investigation, consistent with visible judicial resolution carrying legitimacy-building power. The lack of procedural fairness qualifies any endorsement of the retributive model.

Elevated trust in courts concentrates among stayers, consistent with intergenerational transmission, and the migrants-only estimate is insignificant. The [Marbach \(2024\)](#) framework matters for legacy studies: cross-sectional comparisons that ignore migration composition can obscure legacy effects among rooted populations or produce spurious associations from selective sorting.

Several limitations should be taken into account. We do not claim strict causal identification, and pre-treatment differences may confound the results despite the robustness battery. The Nigerian Civil War remains a potential confounding factor, and robustness checks do not find no evidence that drives the results. The Afrobarometer does not include court-contact items throughout rounds, so we cannot test whether elevated trust in courts erodes with negative judicial experiences.

The institutional channel through which the state responds to crises shapes the durability of its attitudinal legacy. In the Man Leopard case, judicial resolution built trust in courts that has persisted across generations, while trust from the police investigation that preceded it has proven more fragile. For scholars and policymakers working on institutional legitimacy in post-colonial and post-conflict settings, courts may play a larger role than the literature has recognized in generating durable public trust.

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